

Sorting in Tableau

Sorting in Tableau is used to arrange your data in a particular order, such as:

- A → Z
- Z → A
- Smallest → Largest
- Largest → Smallest

For example, you may want to arrange **Categories according to Sales**, from highest to lowest.

1. Sorting using the Sort Option

You can sort a field using the **Sort** option.

Steps

1. Select the field you want to sort.
2. Click the **Sort** option in the toolbar or relevant field options.
3. Choose:
 - **Ascending**
 - **Descending**
4. If required, select the field by which you want to sort.

Example

You have:

Category	Sales
Furniture	50,000
Technology	80,000
Office Supplies	30,000

Sort by **Sales** → **Descending**:

Category	Sales
Technology	80,000
Furniture	50,000
Office Supplies	30,000

2. Sorting by Right-Clicking the Field/Title

You can also sort directly from the visualization.

Steps

1. Right-click the **field/header/title** you want to sort.
 2. Choose **Sort**.
 3. Select **Ascending** or **Descending**.
 4. Choose the field/measure you want to sort by, if required.
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3. Sorting Using the Arrow on an Axis/Header

In some visualizations, you can click the **sort icon/arrow** that appears when you hover over the relevant axis or header.

Steps

1. Hover over the axis/header.
 2. Click the **Sort** arrow.
 3. Tableau sorts the values.
 4. Click again if you want to change the sort direction.
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4. Sorting Multiple Fields

You can apply sorting at different levels.

For example:

Category → Sub-Category

You might want:

```
Furniture
  Chairs
  Tables
  Bookcases

Technology
  Phones
  Accessories
  Machines
```

You can sort the **Category** and then sort the **Sub-Category** within each Category.

Example

Sort:

Category → Sales → Descending

Then:

Sub-Category → Sales → Descending

This gives you an organized hierarchy where both levels are sorted according to Sales.

5. Clearing All Sorts

If you have applied several sorts and want to remove them together:

Worksheet → Clear → Sorts

This clears the sorting applied to the worksheet.

Easy way to remember

Sort = Arrange the data in the order you want.

Joins, Unions and Relationships in Tableau

These are different ways of **combining data from multiple tables**.

Imagine you have two tables:

Customer Table

Customer ID	Customer Name
101	Rahul
102	Priya

Sales Table

Customer ID	Sales
101	50,000
102	30,000

Both tables have **Customer ID**, which can be used to connect the data.

1. Relationships

A **relationship** connects tables without immediately merging them into one table.

Tableau keeps the tables separate and uses the relationship between them when creating a visualization.

When to use

Use relationships when:

- You have multiple related tables.
- You want Tableau to decide how to combine the tables based on the fields used in the visualization.
- You want to maintain the original tables separately.

How to apply

1. Open the **Data Source** page.
2. Drag the first table onto the canvas.
3. Drag the second table onto the canvas.
4. Tableau creates a **relationship**.
5. Click the relationship line.
6. Select the matching fields.

For example:

```
Customer Table
|
| Customer ID
|
Sales Table
```

2. Joins

A **join** combines two tables based on a common field.

For example:

```
Customer ID
```

exists in both tables.

You can join them using Customer ID.

Common Join Types

Join	Meaning
Inner Join	Keeps matching records from both tables
Left Join	Keeps all records from the left table + matching records from right
Right Join	Keeps all records from the right table + matching records from left
Full Outer Join	Keeps records from both tables

Example

Table A

ID	Name
1	A
2	B

Table B

ID	Sales
1	100
3	300

Inner Join:

ID	Name	Sales
1	A	100

Only matching ID **1** remains.

How to apply a Join

1. Go to the **Data Source** page.
2. Drag the first table into the canvas.
3. Drag another table next to it.
4. Tableau opens the **Join** area.
5. Select the join type:
 - Inner
 - Left
 - Right
 - Full Outer
6. Select the fields used to join the tables.

Example:

```
Customer.ID = Sales.Customer_ID
```

3. Unions

A **union** is different from a join.

A union **stacks tables on top of each other**.

Suppose you have:

Sales 2025

Product	Sales
A	100
B	200

Sales 2026

Product	Sales
A	150
B	250

A union produces:

Product	Sales
A	100
B	200
A	150
B	250

So:

Union = Add rows

How to apply a Union

1. Go to the **Data Source** page.
2. Drag the first table onto the canvas.
3. Drag the second table **below the first table**.
4. Tableau shows the **Union** option.
5. Select **Union**.
6. Add the tables you want to combine.

Union is commonly useful when you have:

- Sales 2024
- Sales 2025
- Sales 2026

with the **same column structure**.

Join vs Union vs Relationship

Feature	Join	Union	Relationship
Basic idea	Combines columns	Combines rows	Connects tables
Direction	Side-by-side	Top-to-bottom	Logical connection
Requires common field?	Yes	Usually same/similar columns	Yes, matching fields
Example	Customer + Sales	2025 Sales + 2026 Sales	Customer ↔ Sales
Main purpose	Combine related data	Stack similar tables	Work with multiple related tables

Easy way to remember

JOIN → Side by side

```
Table A | Table B
```

UNION → One below another

```
Table A  
Table A  
Table B  
Table B
```

RELATIONSHIP → Connect tables

```
Table A — Table B
```

One important point

If you have **different tables describing related things**, such as:

```
Customers ↔ Orders
```

a **relationship** can be used.

If you want to physically combine columns from two tables based on a key:

```
Customer ID → Customer ID
```

use a **join**.

If you have tables with the **same type of columns** that you want to stack:

```
January Sales + February Sales + March Sales
```

use a **union**.